

The Data Center Stack

A framework for understanding the data center industry.

LAYER		LAYER & DESCRIPTION	FUNCTION & WHO OPERATES HERE
6 TOP		WORKLOADS Applications, AI, SaaS and enterprise services that generate value and drive outcomes.	CONSUME • SaaS and content companies • AI companies • Enterprise business units
5		PLATFORM The abstraction layer that makes physical infrastructure consumable: virtualization, orchestration and cloud services.	PROVISION • Cloud providers and hyperscalers • Enterprise IT • Managed hosting providers
4		OPERATIONS The continuous work that keeps production infrastructure reliable and available: monitoring, security, maintenance and optimization.	RUN • Colocation providers • Enterprise IT and MSPs • NOC and SOC teams
3		DEPLOYMENT Receive, stage, install, integrate, relocate and decommission infrastructure across its lifecycle.	INSTALL • Field services and smart hands • Integrators and logistics providers • ITAD and decommissioning firms
2		INFRASTRUCTURE The physical and digital building blocks: compute, storage, network, power, cooling, connectivity, security and software.	SUPPLY • OEMs and software vendors • Distributors • Carriers
1 BASE		FOUNDATION Land, power, water, structure and the physical facility everything else depends on.	BUILD • Utilities • Developers • General contractors and MEP firms



1. Each layer depends on the one below it. Nothing at the top runs without everything below it.



2. The stack represents functions, not companies. Most organizations operate across several layers.



3. No layer is optional. Layers can be outsourced, but never skipped.



4. Some functions span every layer. Security, connectivity, and compliance appear at each level.